

Current Affairs — The Hindu | June 16–17, 2026

June 16–17, 2026 | The Hindu Newspaper Analysis

15 HIGH + 9 MEDIUM + 5 LOW Items

UPSC Prelims + Mains | GS-I, GS-II, GS-III, GS-IV

Generated: June 20, 2026

Facts from official sources | Inferences clearly marked | No fabricated data

HIGH

H1 — US-Iran MoU: Ceasefire & Hormuz Deal

■ NEWS TRIGGER

US and Iran signed a Memorandum of Understanding on June 15, 2026, agreeing to a 60-day ceasefire and reopening the Strait of Hormuz to international shipping. Formal ceremony set for Geneva, June 19. Pakistan and Qatar acted as mediators. Israel was NOT a party to the deal.

■ INTRO & ORIGIN

The US-Iran MoU of June 2026 marks a significant de-escalation after weeks of military standoff. The deal reopens the Strait of Hormuz — a critical global oil chokepoint — and initiates a 60-day clock for broader negotiations including nuclear talks.

Tensions escalated after US strikes on Iranian proxy forces in Iraq (April 2026). Pakistan offered backchannel diplomacy; Qatar hosted indirect talks since May 2026. The MoU was signed June 15; formal ceremony at Geneva June 19.

■ TIMELINE

April 2026 — US strikes on Iranian proxies in Iraq; Iran threatens Hormuz closure

May 2026 — Qatar + Pakistan begin backchannel diplomacy

June 15, 2026 — US-Iran MoU signed — 60-day ceasefire + Hormuz reopened

June 19, 2026 — Formal ceremony at Geneva scheduled

2015 — JCPOA signed (P5+1 + Iran); US withdrew 2018 under Trump

■ KEY DATA

Dimension	Detail
Parties	USA + Iran (Israel NOT a party)
Mediators	Pakistan + Qatar
Ceasefire duration	60 days
Hormuz location	Persian Gulf to Gulf of Oman
Oil through Hormuz	~20% of global oil trade
Nuclear talks	Deferred — separate track
Venue for ceremony	Geneva, June 19, 2026

■ STATIC THEORY

- Strait of Hormuz: separates Persian Gulf from Gulf of Oman; NOT directly Arabian Sea
- JCPOA = Joint Comprehensive Plan of Action; signed 2015 by P5+1 (not G7/IAEA)
- P5+1 = USA, UK, France, Russia, China + Germany
- Iran = Non-Nuclear Weapon State (NNWS) signatory to NPT; violated enrichment limits
- MoU = non-binding in international law; Treaty = binding under Vienna Convention 1969
- Pakistan-Iran relations: shared border (Balochistan), trade, Sunni-Shia dimension

- Qatar diplomacy: hosts US CENTCOM; also hosted Taliban + Hamas talks

■ MUST-KNOW FACTS

1. MoU signed: June 15, 2026
2. Formal ceremony: Geneva, June 19
3. Ceasefire: 60 days
4. Mediators: Pakistan + Qatar
5. Israel: NOT a party
6. Hormuz: Persian Gulf to Gulf of Oman (~20% global oil)
7. Nuclear talks: deferred to separate track
8. JCPOA parties: P5+1 (USA, UK, France, Russia, China, Germany) + Iran

■ UPSC TRAPS

- ✗ Israel was a party to the MoU
- ✓ Israel was explicitly NOT a party — separate bilateral track
- ✗ Hormuz connects Persian Gulf to Arabian Sea directly
- ✓ Hormuz connects Persian Gulf to Gulf of Oman; Gulf of Oman opens to Arabian Sea
- ✗ JCPOA was signed by G7 or IAEA
- ✓ JCPOA = P5+1 (five UNSC permanent members + Germany)
- ✗ MoU is legally binding like a treaty
- ✓ MoU is non-binding; Treaty is binding under Vienna Convention 1969

■ MAINS ANGLE

How does the US-Iran MoU affect India's energy security and West Asia diplomacy? Examine India's strategic interests in the Hormuz region.

■ STUDY LINK

IR: Straits and Chokepoints; West Asia policy; NPT/JCPOA framework

HIGH

H2 — Justice Naolekar Committee on Demographic Change

GS-II:
Governance &
Polity Polity/Gov
ernance

■ NEWS TRIGGER

Ministry of Home Affairs (MHA) in May 2026 constituted a 6-member committee headed by Justice P.P. Naolekar (Retd. Supreme Court) to study 'unnatural demographic change' in border districts. Committee has 1-year deadline (May 2027) and is advisory only.

■ INTRO & ORIGIN

The Naolekar Committee is an MHA advisory body examining demographic shifts in India's border districts — primarily in NE India and J&K — linked to illegal immigration and cross-border movement.

Concerns about demographic change in Assam, West Bengal border districts, and J&K have been recurring since the 1980s. The 2019 NRC exercise in Assam was a predecessor attempt. MHA constituted this committee in May 2026 with a specific mandate on 'unnatural' demographic change.

■ TIMELINE

1985 — Assam Accord — addressed illegal immigration from Bangladesh

2019 — NRC Assam — 19 lakh excluded from final list

2019 — CAA enacted — fast-track citizenship for 6 persecuted minorities

May 2026 — MHA constitutes Naolekar Committee (6 members, 1-year mandate)

May 2027 — Committee deadline for submission

■ KEY DATA

Parameter	Detail
Committee head	Justice P.P. Naolekar (Retd. SC Judge)
Constituted by	Ministry of Home Affairs (MHA), May 2026
Members	6 total incl. Census Commissioner + Dr. Shamika Ravi
Mandate	Study 'unnatural demographic change' in border districts
Nature	Advisory only — NO enforcement powers
Timeline	1 year — report by May 2027

■ STATIC THEORY

- Article 355: Centre's duty to protect states from external aggression and internal disturbance
- Foreigners Act 1946 + Foreigners Tribunals — key legal mechanisms for detecting illegal migrants
- NRC = National Register of Citizens; conducted in Assam under SC supervision
- CAA 2019: fast-track citizenship for Hindus, Sikhs, Buddhists, Jains, Parsis, Christians from Pak/Bangladesh/Afghanistan
- Census Commissioner is under Registrar General of India (RGI), under MHA

■ MUST-KNOW FACTS

1. Headed by: Justice P.P. Naolekar (Retd. SC)
2. Constituted: May 2026 by MHA
3. Members: 6 (includes Census Commissioner + Dr. Shamika Ravi)
4. Mandate: 'Unnatural demographic change' in border districts
5. Nature: Advisory ONLY — no enforcement power
6. Deadline: May 2027 (1 year)

■ UPSC TRAPS

- ✗ Committee has powers to deport illegal immigrants
- ✓ Advisory only — it studies and recommends; no enforcement power
- ✗ NRC is a national exercise currently underway
- ✓ NRC was conducted only in Assam (2019); no national NRC yet

■ MAINS ANGLE

Critically examine the constitutional and ethical dimensions of studying 'demographic change' as a governance challenge in India's border districts.

■ STUDY LINK

Polity: Internal Security; Illegal immigration; Citizenship provisions; Article 355

HIGH

H3 — Monsoon Deficit 2026 + El Nino

GS-I:
Geography;
GS-III:
Agriculture Geog
raphy/Agriculture

■ NEWS TRIGGER

As of June 17, 2026, India's southwest monsoon is running 35% below normal. IMD had forecast 90% of LPA but El Nino has intensified. Central India faces -61% deficit. Mumbai unreached. Kharif sowing down by 2 lakh hectares vs last year.

■ INTRO & ORIGIN

■ TIMELINE

India's 2026 southwest monsoon has arrived with a severe deficit — 35% below Long Period Average (LPA) as of June 17. El Nino conditions in the Pacific are suppressing the monsoon trough. Central India is worst hit at -61%. With Kharif sowing lagging, food security and inflation risks are rising.

The southwest monsoon (June-September) contributes ~75% of India's annual rainfall. IMD's April 2026 forecast projected 90% LPA. However, El Nino declared in May 2026 has delayed onset and reduced intensity. The monsoon reached Kerala on June 5 (normal: June 1) but stalled thereafter.

Normal — Monsoon reaches Kerala: June 1; Mumbai: June 10

2026 actual — Kerala: June 5 (4-day delay); Mumbai: unreached as of June 17

May 2026 — El Nino formally declared by IMD/WMO

April 2026 — IMD forecast: 90% LPA (below normal)

June 17 — Actual deficit: 35% below LPA; Central India -61%

■ KEY DATA

Metric	Value
Overall deficit (June 17)	35% below LPA
Central India deficit	-61%
IMD forecast	90% of LPA
LPA definition	50-year average rainfall (1971-2020)
Kharif sowing lag	2 lakh hectares below last year
Districts affected	~200 districts

■ STATIC THEORY

- LPA = Long Period Average: average rainfall over 50 years (currently 1971-2020 base period)
- Normal monsoon = 96-104% of LPA; Below normal = 90-96%; Deficient = below 90%
- El Nino = warming of central/eastern Pacific SST: weakens SW monsoon over India
- La Nina = opposite: usually ABOVE normal monsoon in India
- KHARIF crops: sown June-July, harvested Oct-Nov: Rice, Maize, Cotton, Soybean, Groundnut, Jowar, Bajra
- RABI crops: sown Oct-Nov, harvested March-April: Wheat, Mustard, Gram, Barley, Lentil
- ZAID crops: between Rabi and Kharif (Feb-May): Watermelon, Cucumber, Muskmelon

■ MUST-KNOW FACTS

1. June 17 deficit: 35% below LPA
2. Central India: -61%
3. IMD forecast: 90% LPA (below normal already)
4. Mumbai: unreached as of June 17 (normal: June 10)
5. El Nino declared: May 2026
6. LPA = 50-year avg (1971-2020)
7. Kharif sowing: 2 lakh ha below normal

■ UPSC TRAPS

- ✗ LPA is calculated over 30 years
- ✓ LPA = 50-year average (1971-2020 is current base period)
- ✗ Rice and Wheat are both Kharif crops
- ✓ Rice = Kharif; Wheat = Rabi
- ✗ El Nino strengthens the Indian monsoon
- ✓ El Nino weakens SW monsoon; La Nina strengthens it
- ✗ Below normal rainfall = below 90% LPA

✓ Below normal = 90-96% LPA; Deficient = below 90% LPA

■ MAINS ANGLE

Examine how El Nino-induced monsoon deficit threatens India's food security and inflation management. What adaptive measures are needed?

■ STUDY LINK

Geography: Monsoon mechanism; Kharif-Rabi classification; El Nino-La Nina; Agriculture: Crop calendar

HIGH

H4 — Telegram Blocked by MeitY (NEET Leak)

GS-II:
Governance;
GS-III:
Cybersecurity Governance/Technology

■ NEWS TRIGGER

MeitY blocked Telegram from June 16-22, 2026 on NTA's recommendation following abuse of Telegram's message-editing feature to leak NEET-UG 2026 question papers. NEET-UG re-exam scheduled June 21. First large-scale messaging app block under Section 69A IT Act.

■ INTRO & ORIGIN

The Telegram block marks a significant governance moment — the first large-scale blocking of a messaging platform (not just a website) under Section 69A IT Act. The immediate trigger was NEET-UG paper leak via edited messages.

NEET-UG 2026 question papers were leaked via Telegram groups — using message-editing to distribute answers post-exam while evading detection. NTA flagged this to MeitY. Government invoked Section 69A IT Act — the same provision used to ban TikTok in 2020. Section 66A, which criminalised 'offensive messages', was struck down by SC in Shreya Singhal v. Union of India (2015).

■ TIMELINE

2015 — Shreya Singhal v. UoI — SC struck down Section 66A IT Act

2020 — TikTok + 59 Chinese apps banned under Section 69A (national security)

June 16, 2026 — MeitY blocks Telegram (NTA recommendation — NEET paper leak)

June 21, 2026 — NEET-UG re-exam scheduled

June 22, 2026 — Telegram block expires

■ KEY DATA

Legal Provision	Purpose	Key Case
Section 69A IT Act 2000	Block online content/platforms	TikTok ban 2020; Telegram 2026
Section 66A IT Act 2000	Punish 'offensive messages'	STRUCK DOWN — Shreya Singhal 2015
IT Rules 2021	Social media intermediary compliance	Grievance officer, traceability

■ STATIC THEORY

- Section 69A IT Act: Government can direct blocking of ANY online content/platform for national security, sovereignty, public order, decency, or incitement
- Section 66A: Was used to arrest for 'offensive' online speech; SC struck it down in 2015 as unconstitutional (violates Article 19(1)(a))
- Shreya Singhal case (2015): Landmark SC judgment — online speech has same protection as offline speech; Section 66A vague and overbroad

• NTA = National Testing Agency: autonomous body under Education Ministry; conducts NEET, JEE, CUET

■ **MUST-KNOW FACTS**

1. Section invoked: Section 69A IT Act 2000
2. Block period: June 16-22, 2026
3. Reason: NEET-UG paper leak via message-editing feature
4. Recommended by: NTA (National Testing Agency)
5. Re-exam date: June 21, 2026
6. Section 66A struck down: Shreya Singhal v. UoI, 2015

■ **UPSC TRAPS**

- ✗ Section 66A was used to block Telegram
- ✓ Section 66A was struck down in 2015; Section 69A was used for the Telegram block
- ✗ Shreya Singhal case dealt with platform blocking
- ✓ Shreya Singhal (2015) struck down Section 66A criminalising offensive messages
- ✗ NTA is under MeitY
- ✓ NTA is under Ministry of Education; MeitY issued the blocking order

■ **MAINS ANGLE**

Examine the tension between platform accountability and freedom of expression in India's digital governance framework. Is blanket platform blocking under Section 69A proportionate?

■ **STUDY LINK**

Polity: Fundamental Rights (Art 19); IT Act Section 69A; Governance: NTA; Cybersecurity framework

HIGH

H5 — AI vs Traditional Weather Forecasting

GS-III: Science & Technology
Science & Technology

■ **NEWS TRIGGER**

Study in Science Advances journal (2026): AI models (GraphCast, Pangu-Weather, Fuxi) match or outperform ECMWF HRES in 2-10 day forecasts. But AI models fail beyond 14 days due to extrapolation problem — cannot predict truly novel weather patterns.

■ **INTRO & ORIGIN**

AI-based weather forecasting is disrupting traditional Numerical Weather Prediction (NWP). Models like GraphCast (Google DeepMind), Pangu-Weather (Huawei), and Fuxi (Chinese Academy of Sciences) are faster, cheaper and increasingly accurate. However, they have a fundamental limitation: they cannot extrapolate beyond training data.

Traditional weather forecasting uses NWP — solving atmospheric physics equations on supercomputers (e.g., ECMWF). AI models instead train on decades of reanalysis data and learn statistical patterns. They run in minutes vs hours. The Science Advances 2026 study benchmarked AI vs traditional for the first time at scale.

■ **TIMELINE**

- 1979** — ECMWF established — world's leading NWP centre
- 2023** — Google DeepMind releases GraphCast; Huawei releases Pangu-Weather
- 2024** — Fuxi (Chinese Academy) released
- 2026** — Science Advances study: AI matches ECMWF HRES for 2-10 day forecasts

■ **KEY DATA**

Model	Developer	Strength
GraphCast	Google DeepMind	Runs in minutes; matches ECMWF at 10 days

Model	Developer	Strength
Pangu-Weather	Huawei	Efficient; good medium-range accuracy
Fuxi	Chinese Academy of Sciences	Strong in Asian monsoon regions
ECMWF HRES	European NWP Centre	Best physics-based; global benchmark

■ STATIC THEORY

- NWP = Numerical Weather Prediction: solving differential equations (atmosphere as fluid dynamics)
- AI models = data-driven: pattern matching on historical reanalysis data (ERA5)
- Extrapolation problem: AI cannot reliably predict weather patterns outside its training distribution
- ECMWF: intergovernmental organisation (34 member states); headquarters Reading, UK
- IMD = India Meteorological Department: under Ministry of Earth Sciences

■ MUST-KNOW FACTS

1. GraphCast: Google DeepMind
2. Pangu-Weather: Huawei
3. Fuxi: Chinese Academy of Sciences
4. ECMWF = European Centre for Medium-Range Weather Forecasts (HQ: Reading, UK)
5. AI advantage: 2-10 day accuracy; speed (minutes vs hours)
6. AI limitation: extrapolation problem — fails beyond 14 days for novel patterns
7. Published in: Science Advances (2026)

■ UPSC TRAPS

- ✗ GraphCast was developed by Huawei
- ✓ GraphCast = Google DeepMind; Pangu-Weather = Huawei
- ✗ AI weather models are better than NWP in all time ranges
- ✓ AI matches NWP at 2-10 days but fails beyond 14 days for novel/extreme events
- ✗ ECMWF is a UN agency
- ✓ ECMWF is an intergovernmental (not UN) organisation with 34 member states

■ MAINS ANGLE

AI-based weather forecasting offers promise but poses reliability challenges for disaster management. Analyse the opportunities and limitations for a monsoon-dependent country like India.

■ STUDY LINK

Science and Technology: AI applications;
Geography: Weather forecasting; Disaster Management: Early warning systems

HIGH

H6 — Community Forests Reduce Poverty AND Protect Biodiversity

GS-III:
Environment &
Biodiversity
Environment

■ NEWS TRIGGER

Study in Nature Sustainability (2026): 322 community-managed forests across 15 countries (1993-2017) using IFRI data. Found: poverty leads to less biodiversity; alternative livelihoods lead to more biodiversity. Community forests with economic alternatives show BOTH outcomes simultaneously.

■ INTRO & ORIGIN

■ TIMELINE

A landmark 30-year study overturns the 'conservation vs livelihoods' trade-off narrative. Community-managed forests where residents have economic alternatives maintain higher biodiversity AND lower poverty simultaneously. Uses IFRI data — largest ever analysis of community forest outcomes. <i>The 'fortress conservation' model (keeping people out) has dominated policy for decades. Community forest management (CFM) emerged as an alternative — giving local communities rights over forest resources. India's FRA 2006 and Van Panchayats are examples. This Nature Sustainability 2026 study provides the largest empirical evidence base for CFM outcomes.</i>	1993 — IFRI established — longitudinal community forest data collection begins 2006 — India's Forest Rights Act (FRA) — community forest rights recognized 2022 — Kunming-Montreal GBF: 30x30 target (protect 30% land/sea by 2030) 2026 — Nature Sustainability study: 322 forests, 15 countries, 1993-2017
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■ KEY DATA

Finding	Detail
Sample	322 community forests, 15 countries, 1993-2017
Data source	IFRI (International Forestry Resources and Institutions)
Key finding 1	Poverty + dependence on fuelwood/fodder: LESS biodiversity
Key finding 2	Alternative livelihoods available: MORE biodiversity
Policy implication	Poverty reduction programs IN forest communities = biodiversity win
Journal	Nature Sustainability, 2026

■ STATIC THEORY

- CBD (Convention on Biological Diversity): 3 objectives — Conservation, Sustainable Use, Fair & Equitable Benefit Sharing
- Kunming-Montreal GBF (2022): 30x30 target; replaces Aichi Targets
- FRA 2006 (India): recognizes individual + community forest rights of tribal/forest dwellers
- Van Panchayat: village-level forest management body (mainly Uttarakhand)

■ MUST-KNOW FACTS

1. 322 forests, 15 countries, 1993-2017
2. Data: IFRI (International Forestry Resources and Institutions)
3. Journal: Nature Sustainability, 2026
4. Key finding: poverty leads to less biodiversity; alternative livelihoods lead to more
5. CBD 3 objectives: Conservation + Sustainable Use + Benefit Sharing
6. 30x30 target: Kunming-Montreal GBF 2022
7. India's FRA: 2006

■ UPSC TRAPS

- ✗ Community forest management always reduces biodiversity due to human pressure
- ✓ Study shows WITH alternative livelihoods, community forests show HIGHER biodiversity
- ✗ CBD Nagoya Protocol set the 30x30 target
- ✓ 30x30 was set in Kunming-Montreal GBF (2022); Nagoya Protocol (2010) dealt with benefit sharing
- ✗ IFRI is an Indian government body
- ✓ IFRI = International Forestry Resources and Institutions — a global research network

MAINS ANGLE

The Nature Sustainability study challenges the 'conservation vs livelihoods' dichotomy. How can India's forest governance integrate poverty alleviation with biodiversity conservation?

STUDY LINK

Environment: CBD, FRA 2006, Community Forest Management, Kunming-Montreal GBF

HIGH

H7 — Anthropic AI Export Control (Fable 5 + Mythos 5 Disabled)

GS-II:
International
Relations; GS-III:
Technology
Technology/IR

NEWS TRIGGER

Anthropic disabled Fable 5 and Mythos 5 AI models for users outside allied nations under a US export control directive (June 2026). Dual-use AI technology now treated like weapons technology. India NOT included in exempted list — NSG membership remains unresolved.

INTRO & ORIGIN

The US has begun applying export control frameworks to advanced AI models — treating them as dual-use technology like missiles or nuclear material. Anthropic's disabling of Fable 5 and Mythos 5 for non-allied nations marks the first formal enforcement of AI export controls. India's exclusion highlights its still-ambiguous strategic status.

Export control regimes (Wassenaar Arrangement, MTCR, NSG, Australia Group) traditionally cover weapons and delivery systems. Post-2023, US extended EAR (Export Administration Regulations) to advanced AI chips (Nvidia H100). June 2026 directive extends this to frontier AI models themselves. India joined Wassenaar (2017), MTCR (2016), Australia Group (2018) but is NOT in NSG (China blocking since 2016).

TIMELINE

2016 — India joins MTCR (Missile Technology Control Regime)

2017 — India joins Wassenaar Arrangement (conventional arms + dual-use tech)

2018 — India joins Australia Group (chemical/biological weapons precursors)

2016-present — India's NSG bid blocked — China's veto

2023 — US extends EAR to advanced AI chips (Nvidia H100)

June 2026 — AI frontier models become export controlled; Anthropic disables Fable 5 + Mythos 5

KEY DATA

Regime	Covers	India member?
MTCR	Missile tech + delivery systems	Yes (2016)
Wassenaar Arrangement	Conventional arms + dual-use tech	Yes (2017)
Australia Group	Chemical/bio precursors	Yes (2018)
NSG	Nuclear materials + technology	NO — China blocking
AI EAR (new)	Frontier AI models	Partial — case-by-case

STATIC THEORY

- Export control = government restrictions on exporting certain technologies to certain countries
- Dual-use technology = civilian AND military applications (e.g., GPS, AI, encryption)
- EAR = Export Administration Regulations (US Department of Commerce)
- NSG = Nuclear Suppliers Group: controls nuclear material exports; India NOT a member
- MTCR = Missile Technology Control Regime: voluntary; India joined 2016
- Wassenaar = successor to CoCom; 42 members; controls conventional arms + dual-use tech

■ MUST-KNOW FACTS

1. Models disabled: Fable 5 + Mythos 5 (Anthropic)
2. India NOT in NSG (China blocking)
3. India in MTCR (2016), Wassenaar (2017), Australia Group (2018)
4. EAR = US Export Administration Regulations (Dept of Commerce)
5. Dual-use = civilian + military application
6. AI now treated like weapons tech under US export control

■ UPSC TRAPS

- ✗ India is a member of the Nuclear Suppliers Group (NSG)
- ✓ India is NOT in NSG — China has blocked India's membership since 2016
- ✗ Wassenaar covers nuclear materials
- ✓ Wassenaar covers conventional arms + dual-use tech; NSG covers nuclear materials
- ✗ Australia Group covers missile technology
- ✓ Australia Group covers chemical and biological weapons precursors; MTCR covers missiles

■ MAINS ANGLE

How does the extension of US export controls to AI technology affect India's technology sovereignty and its push for strategic autonomy?

■ STUDY LINK

IR: Export control regimes (MTCR, NSG, Wassenaar); Technology: AI governance; India's nuclear/tech diplomacy

HIGH

H8 — Elon Musk Trillionaire + SpaceX IPO

GS-III: Space Technology; Economy Technology/Economy

■ NEWS TRIGGER

SpaceX IPO on June 12, 2026 valued the company at over \$2 trillion, making Elon Musk's net worth cross \$1.1 trillion — the first confirmed trillionaire. Starlink = LEO constellation. India context: IN-SPACE (private space regulator) + NSIL (ISRO commercial arm).

■ INTRO & ORIGIN

SpaceX's IPO marks a turning point for the commercial space economy. At \$2 trillion+, SpaceX is now larger than most nations' GDP. Starlink's 6,000+ LEO satellites have disrupted satellite internet globally. For India, this accelerates pressure to scale IN-SPACE and NSIL to support domestic private space companies.

SpaceX was founded in 2002 by Elon Musk; first private company to dock with ISS (2020). Starlink launched in 2019 — now world's largest LEO constellation with 6,000+ satellites. IN-SPACE established in 2020 under ISRO; NSIL = ISRO's commercial arm. India's Space Policy 2023 opened the sector to private players fully.

■ TIMELINE

- 2002 — SpaceX founded by Elon Musk
- 2019 — Starlink LEO constellation begins deployment

	2020 — IN-SPACe established (Indian National Space Promotion and Authorisation Centre) 2023 — India Space Policy 2023 — private sector fully opened June 12, 2026 — SpaceX IPO: \$2T+ valuation; Musk net worth \$1.1T
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■ KEY DATA

Entity	Role	Key Fact
SpaceX	US private space company	IPO June 12, 2026; \$2T+ valuation
Starlink	SpaceX LEO constellation	6,000+ satellites; broadband internet globally
IN-SPACe	India private space regulator	Authorises + promotes private space activities
NSIL	ISRO commercial arm	NewSpace India Ltd — launches, services
ISRO	Indian national space agency	Under Dept of Space; reports to PM

■ STATIC THEORY

- LEO = Low Earth Orbit: 200-2000 km altitude; faster round trips; lower latency
- MEO = Medium Earth Orbit (2000-35786 km): GPS satellites
- GEO = Geostationary Orbit (35,786 km): INSAT, communication satellites
- IN-SPACe: autonomous body under Dept of Space; single-window for private space actors
- NSIL (NewSpace India Ltd): ISRO's commercial arm for launch services, satellite manufacturing
- India Space Policy 2023: private firms can own satellites, launch vehicles, operate ground stations

■ MUST-KNOW FACTS

1. SpaceX IPO: June 12, 2026
2. Valuation: \$2T+
3. Musk net worth: \$1.1 trillion (first trillionaire)
4. Starlink = SpaceX LEO internet constellation
5. IN-SPACe: India's private space regulator (est. 2020)
6. NSIL: ISRO's commercial arm (NewSpace India Ltd)
7. India Space Policy: 2023

■ UPSC TRAPS

- ✗ NSIL is India's private space regulator
- ✓ IN-SPACe is the regulator; NSIL is ISRO's commercial/business arm
- ✗ Starlink operates in GEO (geostationary) orbit
- ✓ Starlink is a LEO (Low Earth Orbit) constellation — that's its advantage (low latency)
- ✗ IN-SPACe was established under India Space Policy 2023
- ✓ IN-SPACe was established in 2020; Space Policy 2023 further opened the sector

■ MAINS ANGLE

How does the commercial space boom — exemplified by SpaceX's \$2 trillion valuation — create both opportunities and challenges for India's nascent private space sector?

■ STUDY LINK

Science and Technology: Space; IN-SPACe; ISRO; India Space Policy 2023; LEO vs GEO orbits

HIGH

H9 — Noida International Airport (Jewar) Opens

GS-III:
Infrastructure;
GS-II:
Governance Infra
structure/Governance

■ NEWS TRIGGER

Noida International Airport at Jewar (Gautam Buddh Nagar, UP) inaugurated June 16, 2026. Operated by YIAPL (Yamuna International Airport Pvt Ltd) — a subsidiary of Zurich Airport AG. Phase-1 capacity: 12 million passengers/year. Linked to PM GatiShakti.

■ INTRO & ORIGIN

Jewar Airport is India's newest international airport and one of the largest greenfield airport projects. It is the first major airport in the National Capital Region outside Delhi. Operated by Swiss firm Zurich Airport AG via PPP, linked to PM GatiShakti national master plan.

The airport project was approved in 2017; land acquisition began 2019. YIAPL (Yamuna International Airport Pvt Ltd) won the concession — majority-owned by Zurich Airport AG. Unlike most Indian airports, AAI does not operate Jewar — it is a pure PPP concession. PM GatiShakti (launched Oct 2021) provides the multimodal connectivity framework.

■ TIMELINE

2017 — Jewar Airport project approved by UP Government

2019 — Land acquisition begins (Gautam Buddh Nagar)

Oct 2021 — PM GatiShakti National Master Plan launched (16 ministries)

2022 — YIAPL (Zurich Airport AG) wins concession

June 16, 2026 — Inauguration — Phase 1 operational (12M pax/year)

■ KEY DATA

Parameter	Detail
Location	Jewar, Gautam Buddh Nagar, Uttar Pradesh
Operator	YIAPL (subsidiary of Zurich Airport AG)
AAI role	AAI does NOT operate — pure PPP concession
Phase-1 capacity	12 million passengers/year
GatiShakti	National Master Plan: 16 ministries, Oct 2021
Model	PPP (Public-Private Partnership) — greenfield

■ STATIC THEORY

- AAI = Airports Authority of India: operates most Indian airports; under Ministry of Civil Aviation
- PPP = Public-Private Partnership; greenfield = built from scratch (vs brownfield = existing asset)
- PM GatiShakti: launched Oct 2021; integrates 16 ministries for multimodal infrastructure
- UDAN scheme: regional connectivity; subsidised tickets for Tier 2/3 cities
- India is world's 3rd largest aviation market (IATA data)

■ MUST-KNOW FACTS

■ UPSC TRAPS

1. Location: Jewar, Gautam Buddh Nagar, UP 2. Operator: YIAPL (Zurich Airport AG subsidiary) 3. AAI does NOT operate Jewar 4. Phase-1: 12M passengers/year 5. PM GatiShakti: 16 ministries, Oct 2021 6. Inaugurated: June 16, 2026	X Jewar Airport is operated by AAI ✓ AAI does NOT operate Jewar — it is operated by YIAPL (Zurich Airport AG) under PPP concession X PM GatiShakti was launched in 2019 ✓ GatiShakti was launched in October 2021 integrating 16 ministries X Jewar is in Noida district ✓ Jewar is in Gautam Buddh Nagar district (Noida is a city within Gautam Buddh Nagar)
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■ MAINS ANGLE

Jewar airport exemplifies India's PPP model in aviation infrastructure. Evaluate the advantages and risks of foreign-operated greenfield airports under PM GatiShakti.

■ STUDY LINK

Infrastructure: Aviation; PM GatiShakti; PPP model; AAI; UDAN scheme

HIGH

H10 — India Merchandise Exports May 2026: +18%

GS-III: Economy
— Trade
Economy

■ NEWS TRIGGER

India's merchandise exports in May 2026 rose +18% to \$45.2 billion. Imports = \$73.41 billion; trade deficit = \$28.21 billion. PLI scheme (14 sectors, Rs 1.97 lakh crore) driving manufacturing exports. RoDTEP replaced WTO-incompatible MEIS in 2021. \$2 trillion export target by 2030.

■ INTRO & ORIGIN

India's export surge in May 2026 signals improving global demand and domestic manufacturing competitiveness. The +18% growth is driven by electronics, pharma, and engineering goods — sectors where PLI scheme investments are maturing. However, the \$28.21 billion trade deficit remains a structural challenge.

India's export policy evolved: MEIS (Merchandise Exports from India Scheme) was the main incentive but was challenged at WTO as a prohibited subsidy — replaced by RoDTEP (Remission of Duties and Taxes on Exported Products) in 2021. PLI (Production-Linked Incentive) scheme launched 2020-21 covers 14 sectors. \$2 trillion export target set for 2030.

■ TIMELINE

2020-21 — PLI scheme launched — 14 sectors; Rs 1.97 lakh crore outlay

2021 — RoDTEP replaces MEIS (MEIS = WTO-incompatible prohibited subsidy)

2030 target — \$2 trillion merchandise export target

May 2026 — Exports \$45.2B (+18%); imports \$73.41B; deficit \$28.21B

■ KEY DATA

Scheme	Nature	Key Feature
PLI	Production-Linked Incentive	14 sectors; incentive on INCREMENTAL production
RoDTEP	Remission of Duties and Taxes on Exported Products	Refunds embedded taxes — WTO compatible
MEIS	Merchandise Exports from India Scheme	Direct incentive; declared WTO-incompatible; replaced 2021

■ STATIC THEORY

- WTO SCM Agreement: prohibits export subsidies (except for LDCs); MEIS = direct % of FOB value = prohibited
- RoDTEP = remission of taxes embedded in supply chain (not a bonus/incentive): WTO compatible
- PLI = incentive on incremental production above base year: not an export subsidy per se
- Trade deficit = Imports minus Exports (India structurally imports more than it exports)
- Current Account Deficit (CAD) = trade deficit + invisibles (services, remittances, income)

■ MUST-KNOW FACTS

1. May 2026 exports: \$45.2B (+18%)
2. May 2026 imports: \$73.41B
3. Trade deficit: \$28.21B
4. PLI: 14 sectors, Rs 1.97 lakh crore
5. RoDTEP replaced MEIS in 2021
6. MEIS was WTO-incompatible (prohibited export subsidy)
7. \$2 trillion export target: 2030
8. PLI = incentive on INCREMENTAL production (not per-unit subsidy)

■ UPSC TRAPS

- ✗ RoDTEP is a subsidy scheme for exporters
- ✓ RoDTEP = remission (refund) of embedded taxes — not a new subsidy; WTO-compatible
- ✗ PLI provides incentives on total production
- ✓ PLI = incentive on INCREMENTAL production ABOVE a base year
- ✗ MEIS was replaced because it was ineffective
- ✓ MEIS was replaced because it was challenged at WTO as a prohibited export subsidy

■ MAINS ANGLE

India's \$2 trillion export target by 2030 requires structural reforms beyond incentive schemes. Critically examine the role of PLI and RoDTEP in making India an export powerhouse.

■ STUDY LINK

Economy: Trade policy; PLI; RoDTEP vs MEIS; WTO SCM Agreement; Balance of Payments

HIGH

H11 — Ebola Outbreak DRC 2026

GS-II:
International
Health; GS-III:
Disaster
Management Health/International

■ NEWS TRIGGER

DRC Ebola 2026: 782 cases, 181 deaths, 72 new cases in single day (record). Zaire strain. WHO considering PHEIC under IHR 2005. Ervebo (rVSV-ZEBOV) vaccine available. Ring vaccination strategy used. NOT airborne — spreads via direct contact with bodily fluids.

■ INTRO & ORIGIN

The 2026 Ebola outbreak in DRC is one of the largest since the 2014-16 West Africa epidemic. The Zaire strain (~60% fatality) is spreading in urban areas complicating containment. Ervebo vaccine (2019-approved) is being deployed using ring vaccination.

■ TIMELINE

1976 — Ebola first identified — DRC (then Zaire), near Ebola River

DRC has had 14+ Ebola outbreaks since 1976 (when Ebola was first identified near Ebola River). The 2014-16 West Africa outbreak (Guinea, Sierra Leone, Liberia) was the deadliest — 11,000 deaths. Ervebo (rVSV-ZEBOV) became the first approved Ebola vaccine in 2019. WHO's IHR 2005 framework allows Director-General to declare PHEIC.	2014-16 — West Africa Ebola — largest ever: 28,000 cases, 11,000 deaths 2019 — Ervebo (rVSV-ZEBOV) approved — first Ebola vaccine 2026 — DRC Ebola: 782 cases, 181 deaths, 72/day record
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■ KEY DATA

Fact	Detail
Strain	Zaire (most lethal; ~60% fatality rate)
Cases (2026)	782 cases, 181 deaths
Daily record	72 new cases (single day)
Transmission	Direct contact with bodily fluids; NOT airborne
Vaccine	Ervebo (rVSV-ZEBOV) — approved 2019
Vaccination strategy	Ring vaccination (vaccinate contacts of cases)
WHO alert	PHEIC under IHR 2005 (under consideration)

■ STATIC THEORY

- PHEIC = Public Health Emergency of International Concern: declared by WHO DG under IHR 2005
- IHR 2005 = International Health Regulations — binding on 196 WHO member states
- Ring vaccination: vaccinate contacts + contacts-of-contacts of confirmed cases
- Ebola transmission: direct contact with blood/bodily fluids of symptomatic patient; NOT airborne
- Zaire strain = Ebola virus disease (EVD) most common and most lethal strain

■ MUST-KNOW FACTS

1. 2026 DRC: 782 cases, 181 deaths, 72/day record
2. Strain: Zaire (most lethal)
3. NOT airborne — contact with bodily fluids only
4. Vaccine: Ervebo (rVSV-ZEBOV, 2019)
5. Strategy: Ring vaccination
6. PHEIC: declared by WHO DG under IHR 2005
7. Largest ever: West Africa 2014-16 (11,000 deaths)
8. First identified: 1976, DRC (near Ebola River)

■ UPSC TRAPS

- ✗ Ebola spreads through air droplets
- ✓ Ebola is NOT airborne — spreads only through direct contact with bodily fluids
- ✗ PHEIC is declared by the UN Secretary General
- ✓ PHEIC is declared by WHO Director General under IHR 2005
- ✗ The 2026 outbreak is the largest Ebola outbreak ever
- ✓ Largest Ebola: 2014-16 West Africa (28,000 cases, 11,000 deaths); 2026 = 782 cases

■ MAINS ANGLE

■ STUDY LINK

Recurring Ebola outbreaks in DRC reveal structural gaps in global health security. Assess the role of IHR 2005, ring vaccination, and international solidarity in epidemic preparedness.

Health: Ebola; IHR 2005; PHEIC; Ring vaccination; Zoonotic diseases

GS-II:
International
Relations;
Security
International
Relations

HIGH

H12 — US Military Stockpile in SE Australia (AUKUS Context)

■ NEWS TRIGGER

US establishing pre-positioned military stockpile in SE Australia (near Pine Gap, Alice Springs, NT). Marine Corps logistics base. Context: AUKUS (Sept 2021) — Australia to receive nuclear-POWERED (not nuclear weapons) submarines from US/UK. India NOT in AUKUS.

■ INTRO & ORIGIN

The US pre-positioning of military stockpiles in Australia marks a deepening of the AUKUS security pact. Pine Gap (Alice Springs, NT) is already a joint US-Australia intelligence facility. The new Marine Corps logistics base extends US power projection capability countering China's A2/AD capabilities.

AUKUS was announced September 15, 2021 — Australia, UK, USA. Most consequential: Australia will acquire 8 nuclear-powered submarines (SSNs) built with US/UK technology. Critically, these are nuclear-propulsion only — NO nuclear weapons. QUAD (2007/2017) is a separate forum — India IS in QUAD but NOT in AUKUS.

■ TIMELINE

1966 — Pine Gap established (US-Australia joint intelligence facility)

2007 — QUAD first formed (India, US, Japan, Australia) — lapsed 2008

2017 — QUAD revived at ministerial level

Sept 2021 — AUKUS announced — Australia, UK, USA (India NOT included)

2026 — US pre-positions military stockpile in SE Australia (Marine Corps)

■ KEY DATA

Forum	Members	India?	Key Feature
AUKUS	Australia, UK, USA	NO	Nuclear-powered subs + tech sharing
QUAD	India, US, Japan, Australia	YES	Diplomatic/security forum; no military treaty
Five Eyes	USA, UK, Canada, Australia, NZ	NO	Intelligence sharing
NATO	32 members (N America + Europe)	NO	Art 5 collective defence treaty

■ STATIC THEORY

- AUKUS: Australia gets NUCLEAR-POWERED submarines (SSN) — propulsion is nuclear; weapons are conventional
- SSN vs SSBN: SSN = nuclear-powered sub (no nukes); SSBN = nuclear-armed ballistic missile sub
- A2/AD = Anti-Access/Area Denial: China's strategy to push US military assets away from Taiwan Strait

- Pine Gap = joint US-Australia intelligence facility near Alice Springs, Northern Territory
- QUAD = quadrilateral security dialogue; not a military alliance; no Article 5 equivalent

■ MUST-KNOW FACTS

1. AUKUS: Australia + UK + USA (India NOT member)
2. Announced: September 15, 2021
3. Nuclear-powered submarines (NOT nuclear weapons)
4. Pine Gap: joint intelligence facility, Alice Springs, NT
5. QUAD members: India, US, Japan, Australia
6. India IS in QUAD, NOT in AUKUS or Five Eyes

■ UPSC TRAPS

- ✗ AUKUS involves sharing nuclear weapons with Australia
- ✓ AUKUS = nuclear-POWERED submarines (propulsion only); Australia has no nuclear weapons
- ✗ India is a member of AUKUS
- ✓ India is NOT in AUKUS; India IS in QUAD
- ✗ QUAD and AUKUS are the same alliance
- ✓ QUAD = diplomatic forum (India+US+Japan+Australia); AUKUS = security/tech pact (Australia+UK+USA)

■ MAINS ANGLE

AUKUS deepens US military presence in the Indo-Pacific. How should India calibrate its strategic autonomy between QUAD participation and avoiding entanglement in AUKUS-style alliances?

■ STUDY LINK

IR: AUKUS; QUAD; Indo-Pacific strategy; Nuclear non-proliferation; A2/AD

HIGH

H13 — Iran-US War: Editorial Analysis

GS-II:
International
Relations
International
Relations

■ NEWS TRIGGER

The Hindu editorial: Iran 'won by not losing' — Kissinger principle. US failed all 3 objectives (nuclear rollback, regime change, Hormuz control). Iran's nuclear breakout time = weeks (unchanged). JCPOA context: P5+1. India/Pakistan/Israel never signed NPT.

■ INTRO & ORIGIN

The Hindu's June 17 editorial analyses the Iran-US conflict through Kissinger's 'guerrilla wins by not losing' prism. Iran preserved its nuclear programme, avoided regime change, and maintained Hormuz leverage — despite absorbing US strikes. The US strategic objectives all failed.

Henry Kissinger's insight: in asymmetric conflict, the weaker party wins by surviving; the stronger party must achieve all objectives to 'win'. Iran's JCPOA violations (enrichment to 60%+) brought breakout time from 1 year (2015) to weeks. Three key nuclear sites: Natanz (centrifuges), Fordow (underground), Arak (heavy water). NPT framework: NWS (5) vs NNWS (185+) vs never signed (India, Pakistan, Israel); North Korea signed then withdrew 2003.

■ TIMELINE

1968 — NPT opened for signature; entered force 1970

2003 — North Korea withdraws from NPT

2015 — JCPOA signed — P5+1 + Iran; breakout time extended to ~1 year

2018 — Trump withdraws US from JCPOA; 'maximum pressure'

2026 — US strikes on Iranian nuclear sites; Iran absorbs + retaliates; MoU June 15

■ KEY DATA

Category	Countries	NPT Status
NWS (Nuclear Weapon States)	USA, UK, France, Russia, China	Recognised under NPT Art 9
NNWS (Non-Nuclear Weapon States)	Iran, Germany, Japan, most countries	Signed NPT; no weapons allowed
Never signed NPT	India, Pakistan, Israel	Outside NPT framework
Withdrew from NPT	North Korea (2003)	Tested weapons post-withdrawal

■ STATIC THEORY

- NPT = Non-Proliferation Treaty: 3 pillars — Non-proliferation, Disarmament, Peaceful use of nuclear energy
- P5+1 = 5 permanent UNSC members + Germany (NOT G7, NOT IAEA)
- JCPOA (2015): Iran agreed to limit enrichment to 3.67%, cap centrifuges — in exchange for sanctions relief
- Breakout time = time needed to produce enough weapons-grade uranium for one bomb
- Iran = NNWS signatory to NPT who violated limits — different from India/Pak/Israel who never signed
- Natanz = main enrichment site; Fordow = underground hardened facility; Arak = heavy water reactor

■ MUST-KNOW FACTS

1. P5+1: USA, UK, France, Russia, China + Germany (NOT G7/IAEA)
2. JCPOA signed: 2015; US withdrew: 2018
3. Iran = NNWS NPT signatory (violated limits)
4. India, Pakistan, Israel: NEVER signed NPT
5. North Korea: signed NPT, withdrew 2003
6. Breakout time (2026): weeks (was ~1 year in 2015)
7. Key sites: Natanz, Fordow, Arak

■ UPSC TRAPS

- ✗ JCPOA was an agreement between Iran and IAEA
- ✓ JCPOA = Iran + P5+1 (USA, UK, France, Russia, China, Germany) — IAEA was monitor, NOT party
- ✗ India is a Non-Nuclear Weapon State (NNWS) under NPT
- ✓ India NEVER SIGNED the NPT — it is outside the treaty framework entirely
- ✗ North Korea has never been in the NPT
- ✓ North Korea signed NPT, then WITHDREW in 2003 after testing weapons
- ✗ Breakout time = time to fire a nuclear missile
- ✓ Breakout time = time to produce sufficient weapons-grade uranium for ONE bomb (production, not deployment)

■ MAINS ANGLE

Examine the structural weaknesses of the NPT regime exposed by the Iran nuclear crisis. What are the implications for global nuclear order and India's strategic interests?

■ STUDY LINK

IR: NPT; JCPOA; P5+1; Nuclear non-proliferation regime; Iran policy

HIGH

H14 — IRDAI: 100% FDI in Insurance Proposed

GS-III: Economy
— Insurance
Sector Economy

■ NEWS TRIGGER

IRDAI proposing 100% FDI in insurance sector (from current 74%). FDI journey: 26%(2000) to 49%(2015) to 74%(2021) to 100%(proposed 2026). Composite insurance (life + non-life together) also proposed. Insurance penetration in India ~4% of GDP vs global avg 7%.

■ INTRO & ORIGIN

India's insurance regulator IRDAI is pushing for 100% FDI to attract foreign capital and deepen insurance penetration — currently only ~4% of GDP vs global average of ~7%. The move will allow foreign insurers to own Indian insurance companies outright. Composite insurance (combined life + non-life license) will reduce entry barriers.

Insurance sector was opened to private players in 2000 with 26% FDI cap. Insurance Laws (Amendment) Act 2015 raised it to 49%. Finance Act 2021 raised to 74%. Now Budget 2026-27 proposes full 100%. IRDAI = Insurance Regulatory and Development Authority of India, established under IRDAI Act 1999.

■ TIMELINE

1999 — IRDAI Act passed — IRDAI established as statutory regulator

2000 — Insurance sector opened to private players; FDI cap = 26%

2015 — Insurance Laws Amendment Act: FDI raised to 49%

2021 — Finance Act 2021: FDI raised to 74%

2026 — Budget 2026-27 proposes 100% FDI + composite insurance

■ KEY DATA

Year	FDI Cap	Instrument
2000	26%	Insurance sector opened to private players
2015	49%	Insurance Laws (Amendment) Act 2015
2021	74%	Finance Act 2021
2026 (proposed)	100%	Budget 2026-27 proposal

■ STATIC THEORY

- IRDAI = Insurance Regulatory and Development Authority of India: statutory body under IRDAI Act 1999
- IRDAI HQ: Hyderabad
- IRDAI regulates: Life insurance, General insurance (non-life), Reinsurance, Insurance intermediaries
- LIC = Life Insurance Corporation: government-owned; dominates life insurance market
- Insurance penetration = premium as % of GDP; India ~4% vs global ~7%
- Composite insurance = combined license for both life AND non-life insurance (currently separate)

■ MUST-KNOW FACTS

1. IRDAI Act: 1999
2. IRDAI HQ: Hyderabad
3. FDI journey: 26%(2000) to 49%(2015) to 74%(2021) to 100%(proposed)
4. Composite insurance: life + non-life combined license

■ UPSC TRAPS

- ✗ IRDAI was established under Insurance Act 1938
- ✓ IRDAI was established under IRDAI Act 1999; Insurance Act 1938 governs insurance companies
- ✗ Composite insurance means mixing health and life insurance
- ✓ Composite = one entity can offer BOTH life AND non-life (general) insurance under a single license

5. Insurance penetration: ~4% GDP (India) vs ~7% global 6. LIC = government-owned life insurer (dominant player)	✗ FDI cap was raised to 74% in 2015 ✓ 74% cap came in 2021 (Finance Act); 2015 raised it to 49%
■ MAINS ANGLE 100% FDI in insurance: Will it deepen penetration or create risks of capital outflows and foreign dominance in a systemically important sector? Critically examine.	■ STUDY LINK Economy: Insurance sector; IRDAI; FDI policy; Financial inclusion; GDP measures

HIGH

H15 — India Battery Energy Storage +941% Growth

GS-III: Energy; Environment Economy/Environment

NEWS TRIGGER

India's Battery Energy Storage System (BESS) capacity grew +941% in Q1 2026 — 4.6 GWh added. Cumulative BESS: 5.9 GWh. PLI for Advanced Chemistry Cell (ACC): Rs 18,100 crore, 50 GWh target. 500 GW renewable by 2030, Net Zero by 2070 (COP26 commitment).

INTRO & ORIGIN

India's battery storage sector has exploded — 941% growth in Q1 2026 signals the energy transition is accelerating. BESS is critical to India's 500 GW renewable energy target by 2030 because solar/wind are intermittent — batteries smooth supply. PLI for ACC manufacturing is driving domestic production.

India committed at COP26 (Glasgow, Nov 2021) to: 500 GW non-fossil capacity by 2030, 50% energy from renewables by 2030, Net Zero by 2070. BESS is the missing link — without storage, solar panels only work when the sun shines. PLI for ACC (Rs 18,100 crore) was announced in 2021 to create 50 GWh domestic battery manufacturing.

TIMELINE

2021 — COP26 Glasgow: India's Panchamrit commitments (500 GW, 50% RE, Net Zero 2070)

2021 — PLI for ACC: Rs 18,100 crore; 50 GWh target

2023 — BESS deployments begin to scale

Q1 2026 — 4.6 GWh BESS added (+941% YoY); cumulative 5.9 GWh

KEY DATA

Metric	Value
Q1 2026 BESS addition	4.6 GWh (+941% YoY)
Cumulative BESS	5.9 GWh
PLI for ACC	Rs 18,100 crore; target = 50 GWh manufacturing
500 GW RE target	By 2030 (COP26 commitment)
Net Zero target	2070 (India; USA/EU = 2050)
BESS full form	Battery Energy Storage System
ACC full form	Advanced Chemistry Cell

STATIC THEORY

- Panchamrit (COP26): 500 GW non-fossil by 2030; 50% energy from renewables by 2030; reduce emissions intensity 45% by 2030; Net Zero 2070; carbon sink 2.5-3 billion tonnes

- BESS = Battery Energy Storage System: stores electricity (typically lithium-ion or flow batteries)
- ACC = Advanced Chemistry Cell: high-performance batteries for EVs and grid storage
- PLI = Production Linked Incentive: incentive on incremental production (not a direct export subsidy)
- GWh = Gigawatt-hour = unit of energy storage; GW = Gigawatt = unit of power capacity

■ MUST-KNOW FACTS

1. Q1 2026: 4.6 GWh BESS added (+941%)
2. Cumulative: 5.9 GWh
3. PLI for ACC: Rs 18,100 crore; 50 GWh target
4. India Net Zero: 2070 (COP26)
5. 500 GW RE target: 2030
6. BESS = Battery Energy Storage System
7. ACC = Advanced Chemistry Cell

■ UPSC TRAPS

- ✗ India's Net Zero target is 2050 like the US
- ✓ India's Net Zero is 2070; USA and EU target 2050
- ✗ PLI for ACC covers 100 GWh of battery manufacturing
- ✓ PLI for ACC = 50 GWh target; Rs 18,100 crore outlay
- ✗ GW and GWh are the same unit
- ✓ GW = power (rate of energy); GWh = energy stored (GW x hours). BESS is measured in GWh

■ MAINS ANGLE

India's 941% BESS growth is impressive but represents only 5.9 GWh against a 500 GW renewable target. What policy interventions are needed to scale energy storage to match renewable ambition?

■ STUDY LINK

Environment: COP26; Panchamrit; Energy: PLI for ACC; BESS; Renewable energy targets

■ MEDIUM UPSC RELEVANCE

MEDIUM

M1 — J&K Statehood: Omar Abdullah Sit-in at Jantar Mantar

GS-II: Polity & Governance
Polity

■ NEWS TRIGGER

J&K Chief Minister Omar Abdullah staged a sit-in protest at Jantar Mantar, New Delhi (June 17) demanding restoration of J&K's statehood. J&K has been a Union Territory since Aug 5, 2019 (Reorganisation Act). Paharis granted ST status — 20% quota in J&K.

■ INTRO & ORIGIN

Omar Abdullah's public sit-in marks an escalation of J&K's statehood demand. The Supreme Court in December 2023 upheld constitutional validity of Article 370 abrogation but asked the Centre to restore statehood 'at the earliest'. The demand remains unresolved.

Article 370 was abrogated on August 5, 2019. J&K was bifurcated into two UTs: J&K (with legislature) and Ladakh (without legislature). Paharis were granted ST status in April 2023 — granting 20% reservation, which triggered protests from existing ST communities (Gujjars, Bakerwals).

■ TIMELINE

Aug 5, 2019 — Article 370 abrogated; J&K bifurcated into two UTs

April 2023 — Paharis granted Scheduled Tribe status (20% quota)

Dec 2023 — SC upholds Art 370 abrogation; asks Centre to restore statehood 'at earliest'

June 17, 2026 — Omar Abdullah sit-in at Jantar Mantar demanding statehood

■ KEY DATA

Issue	Status
J&K; current status	Union Territory (with legislature)
Ladakh status	Union Territory (WITHOUT legislature)
Statehood demand	Unmet; SC asked Centre to restore 'at earliest'
Paharis ST quota	20% in J&K; (granted April 2023)

■ STATIC THEORY

- Article 370: Gave J&K special status; abrogated Aug 5, 2019 by Presidential Order
- UT with legislature: J&K, Delhi, Puducherry — legislature but limited powers vs full state
- ST reservation: Presidential list; requires Constitutional amendment (Article 342)

■ MUST-KNOW FACTS

1. J&K UT since: August 5, 2019
2. SC verdict: December 2023 — upheld Art 370 abrogation
3. Paharis: ST status April 2023; 20% quota
4. Ladakh: UT without legislature (unlike J&K)

■ UPSC TRAPS

- ✗ Ladakh has a legislature like J&K
- ✓ Ladakh = UT without legislature; J&K = UT WITH legislature
- ✗ SC struck down Article 370 abrogation
- ✓ SC UPHELD the abrogation but asked Centre to restore statehood at earliest

■ MAINS ANGLE

Examine the constitutional and political dimensions of J&K statehood restoration. How does the Pahari ST issue complicate the political landscape?

■ STUDY LINK

Polity: Article 370; J&K Reorganisation Act 2019; UT governance; ST status provisions

MEDIUM

M2 — SC: Aadhaar Misuse Plea

GS-II: Polity —
Fundamental
Rights Polity

■ NEWS TRIGGER

Supreme Court issued notice to Centre and all States on a PIL alleging systemic Aadhaar misuse — biometric data used without consent for surveillance and denial of benefits. SC sought reply in 8 weeks. Aadhaar Act 2016 + Puttaswamy judgment 2017 context.

■ INTRO & ORIGIN

The SC notice signals judicial scrutiny of how Aadhaar's biometric infrastructure is being used beyond its statutory purpose. The Puttaswamy judgment (2017) recognised privacy as a fundamental right under Article 21. The Aadhaar Act was amended in 2019 to allow voluntary use.

Aadhaar was challenged in Puttaswamy v. Union of India (2018 Constitution Bench): upheld Aadhaar but struck down mandatory linking for bank accounts, mobile numbers. Aadhaar Amendment Act 2019 allowed private entities to use Aadhaar with consent. The new PIL alleges this has been abused.

■ TIMELINE

2009 — UIDAI established; Aadhaar programme begins

2016 — Aadhaar Act 2016 enacted

2017 — Puttaswamy-I: Privacy = FR under Article 21

	2018 — Puttaswamy-II (Constitution Bench): Aadhaar upheld; bank/mobile linking struck down 2019 — Aadhaar Amendment Act: private entity use allowed with consent June 2026 — SC notice to Centre+States on systemic misuse PIL
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■ KEY DATA

Case	Year	Ruling
Puttaswamy-I	2017	Privacy = Fundamental Right under Article 21
Puttaswamy-II	2018	Aadhaar upheld; mandatory bank/mobile linking struck down
Aadhaar Amendment	2019	Private entity use allowed with consent

■ STATIC THEORY

- Right to Privacy: FR under Article 21 (Puttaswamy 2017, 9-judge bench unanimous)
- Aadhaar = 12-digit biometric identity (fingerprint + iris + face); issued by UIDAI
- UIDAI = Unique Identification Authority of India; statutory body under Aadhaar Act 2016
- Doctrine of Proportionality: law limiting fundamental rights must be proportionate to objective

■ MUST-KNOW FACTS

1. Aadhaar Act: 2016
2. UIDAI: statutory body under Aadhaar Act 2016
3. Puttaswamy (2017): Privacy = FR under Art 21
4. Puttaswamy (2018): Aadhaar upheld; mandatory bank/mobile linking struck down
5. Amendment 2019: private entity use allowed with consent

■ UPSC TRAPS

- ✗ Puttaswamy 2017 upheld Aadhaar
- ✓ Puttaswamy 2017 = privacy as FR; Puttaswamy 2018 (Constitution Bench) = upheld Aadhaar but struck down mandatory linking
- ✗ UIDAI is under Ministry of IT
- ✓ UIDAI is under Ministry of Electronics and IT (MeitY)

■ MAINS ANGLE

How do constitutional safeguards around Aadhaar balance the state's interest in efficient welfare delivery with citizens' right to privacy?

■ STUDY LINK

Polity: Article 21; Puttaswamy judgment; UIDAI; Aadhaar governance

MEDIUM M3 — RSS Legal Status Controversy (Karnataka)	GS-II: Polity — Civil Society Polity
■ NEWS TRIGGER Karnataka Home Minister Priyank Kharge vs RSS chief Mohan Bhagwat on RSS's legal registration status. RSS claims it is a 'cultural organisation', not a political party. Dispute centres on FCRA, party registration, and legal accountability.	
■ INTRO & ORIGIN	■ TIMELINE

The Karnataka government's scrutiny of RSS's legal registration status raises fundamental questions about civil society organisations that exercise significant political influence without formal party status.

RSS (Rashtriya Swayamsevak Sangh) was founded in 1925 by K.B. Hedgewar in Nagpur. It has been banned three times (1948, 1975, 1992) and de-banned each time after court interventions. RSS is affiliated with BJP but legally separate. FCRA compliance is the current dispute.

1925 — RSS founded by K.B. Hedgewar in Nagpur

1948 — First RSS ban (post Gandhi assassination — later lifted)

1975 — Second ban (Emergency period)

1992 — Third ban (post Babri Masjid demolition — lifted 1993)

June 2026 — Karnataka HM raises RSS legal registration dispute

■ KEY DATA

Fact	Detail
Founded	1925, Nagpur, by K.B. Hedgewar
Times banned	3 (1948, 1975, 1992) — all lifted
Legal status	Cultural/social organisation (not political party)
FCRA	Foreign Contribution Regulation Act 2010

■ STATIC THEORY

- Freedom of Association: Article 19(1)(c) — right to form associations/unions
- FCRA 2010: regulates foreign funding of NGOs/associations in India
- Representation of the People Act 1951: governs political parties and elections
- Societies Registration Act 1860: registration of literary, scientific, charitable societies

■ MUST-KNOW FACTS

1. RSS founded: 1925, Nagpur, by K.B. Hedgewar
2. RSS bans: 1948, 1975, 1992 (all lifted)
3. RSS = cultural organisation (not registered as political party)
4. FCRA = Foreign Contribution Regulation Act 2010
5. Article 19(1)(c): Right to form associations

■ UPSC TRAPS

- ✗ RSS is registered as a political party
- ✓ RSS is a cultural/social organisation — legally distinct from BJP
- ✗ RSS has never been banned in India
- ✓ RSS was banned THREE times: 1948, 1975, 1992

■ MAINS ANGLE

What accountability framework should govern large civil society organisations that exercise significant political influence without formal political party status?

■ STUDY LINK

Polity: Article 19; Civil society; FCRA; Political parties vs organisations

MEDIUM

M4 — Census 2027 Phase-1 Begins in Delhi

GS-II:
Governance
Governance

■ NEWS TRIGGER

Census 2027 Phase-1 (house listing and housing census) begins in Delhi. 54.98 lakh households to be enumerated. First census since 2011 (2021 census delayed due to COVID). Census Commissioner under Registrar General of India (RGI), under MHA.

■ INTRO & ORIGIN

India's Census has been delayed by 5 years — from 2021 to 2027 — due to COVID and subsequent delays. The Delhi Phase-1 commencement signals the process is finally moving. Census data drives delimitation, reservation reviews, welfare targeting, and policy planning across all sectors.

India conducts Census every 10 years under Census Act 1948. The 2021 Census was first postponed due to COVID (March 2020), then delayed repeatedly. The Registrar General of India (RGI) under MHA oversees Census. Post-Census: delimitation of parliamentary constituencies occurs.

■ TIMELINE

1948 — Census Act 1948 enacted

2011 — Last completed Census

2021 — Census due; postponed due to COVID

2026 — Phase-1 Delhi (house listing) begins

2027 — Full Census enumeration target

■ KEY DATA

Parameter	Detail
Delhi households	54.98 lakh (Phase-1 count)
Last Census	2011
Census Act	1948
Conducted by	RGI under MHA
Delay reason	COVID-19 + administrative delays

■ STATIC THEORY

- Census Act 1948: legal basis for Census; RGI conducts under MHA
- Census phases: (1) House listing and housing census; (2) Population enumeration
- Delimitation: redrawing parliamentary/assembly constituencies based on Census data
- NPR = National Population Register: first step toward NRC; separate from Census

■ MUST-KNOW FACTS

1. Last census: 2011
2. Next census: 2027 (delayed from 2021)
3. Phase-1 Delhi: 54.98 lakh households
4. Census Act: 1948
5. RGI: Registrar General of India (under MHA)

■ UPSC TRAPS

- ✗ Census in India is conducted under Ministry of Statistics
- ✓ Census is under Ministry of Home Affairs (MHA) — conducted by Registrar General of India
- ✗ India's last Census was in 2021
- ✓ 2021 Census was POSTPONED; last completed Census was in 2011

■ MAINS ANGLE

How does a 16-year gap in Census data (2011-2027) affect India's welfare targeting, delimitation, and evidence-based policymaking?

■ STUDY LINK

Governance: Census Act 1948; RGI; Delimitation; NPR-NRC link

MEDIUM

M5 — G7 France Summit: Trump Tariff Threats

■ NEWS TRIGGER

G7 Summit in France: Trump threatened tariffs on EU unless trade imbalances addressed. Macron raised 'macroeconomic imbalances' agenda. G7 = USA, UK, France, Germany, Japan, Italy, Canada + EU. India NOT in G7 but is a regular invitee.

■ INTRO & ORIGIN

The 2026 G7 France Summit was dominated by Trump's tariff threats — signalling continued US economic nationalism. French President Macron pushed for a coordinated response to global macroeconomic imbalances. India's trade relationship with the US is directly affected by any new tariff regime.

G7 was formed after the 1973 oil crisis — originally G6, then G8 (with Russia), now G7 (Russia expelled 2014 after Crimea). India has been a regular invitee to G7 summits since 2019 but is NOT a member. The 'macroeconomic imbalances' debate echoes the IMF's Article IV surveillance mechanism.

■ TIMELINE

1975 — G6 formed (post oil crisis); became G7 with Canada

2014 — Russia expelled after Crimea annexation; G8 to G7

2019 — India becomes regular G7 invitee (Biarritz summit)

2026 — G7 France: Trump tariff threats; Macron macroeconomic agenda

■ KEY DATA

Group	Members	India?
G7	USA, UK, France, Germany, Japan, Italy, Canada + EU	NO — regular invitee
G20	G7 + India, China, Brazil, Russia, etc.	YES — member
G8 (old)	G7 + Russia	Russia expelled 2014

■ STATIC THEORY

- G7 = Group of 7 major advanced economies: USA, UK, France, Germany, Japan, Italy, Canada + EU
- G20 = G7 + emerging economies including India, China, Brazil, Russia, etc.
- Trump tariffs: Section 232 (national security) and Section 301 (unfair trade practices) under US trade law
- WTO DSU (Dispute Settlement Understanding): mechanism to challenge tariffs

■ MUST-KNOW FACTS

1. G7 members: USA, UK, France, Germany, Japan, Italy, Canada + EU
2. India: NOT in G7; regular invitee since 2019
3. Russia: expelled from G8 in 2014 (Crimea) to G7

■ UPSC TRAPS

✗ India is a member of G7

✓ India is NOT a G7 member; it is a regular invitee/guest

✗ G7 includes Russia

4. G7 2026: France (host)

✓ Russia was expelled in 2014 after Crimea; it was G8 before that

■ MAINS ANGLE

How do G7 tariff disputes and macroeconomic imbalance debates affect India's export strategy and its positioning in global trade governance?

■ STUDY LINK

IR: G7; WTO; Trade disputes; India-US economic relations

MEDIUM

M6 — Coral Reef Survival: 1.66 Lakh Sq Km Resilient Reefs

GS-III:
Environment
Environment

■ NEWS TRIGGER

Nature study (2026): 1,66,000 sq km of coral reefs identified as 'thermally resilient' — 3 times previous estimate. These reefs can survive 1.5 degrees C warming threshold. Key for IUCN Red List designations and marine protected area planning.

■ INTRO & ORIGIN

A landmark Nature study triples the estimate of thermally resilient coral reefs — offering hope that significant reef area can survive projected warming if Paris Agreement 1.5 degrees C targets are met. This has direct implications for Marine Protected Area (MPA) planning.

Coral bleaching occurs when sea surface temperatures rise 1 degree C+ above summer maximum — corals expel symbiotic algae (zooxanthellae). The 2016 and 2020 mass bleaching events damaged ~50% of Great Barrier Reef. The Nature 2026 study used 30+ years of thermal satellite data to identify reefs with natural cooling mechanisms.

■ TIMELINE

1998 — First global mass coral bleaching event (El Nino induced)

2016 — Worst bleaching of Great Barrier Reef to date

2016 — Paris Agreement: 1.5 degrees C target

2020 — Second major GBR bleaching

2026 — Nature study: 1,66,000 sq km resilient reefs identified (3x estimate)

■ KEY DATA

Fact	Detail
Resilient reefs found	1,66,000 sq km
vs previous estimate	3x larger
Key threshold	1.5 degrees C (Paris Agreement)
Mechanism	Deep water upwelling provides cooling
India's coral reefs	Gulf of Mannar, Lakshadweep, Gulf of Kutch, A&N;

■ STATIC THEORY

- Coral bleaching: thermal stress causes corals to expel zooxanthellae (symbiotic algae) — turn white — die if prolonged
- Great Barrier Reef: UNESCO World Heritage Site; off Queensland, Australia
- India's coral reefs: Gulf of Mannar, Lakshadweep, Gulf of Kutch, Andaman and Nicobar
- Marine Protected Area (MPA): protected ocean zone under CBD and UNCLOS framework

- 30x30: Kunming-Montreal GBF target to protect 30% of ocean by 2030

■ MUST-KNOW FACTS

1. 1,66,000 sq km: thermally resilient reefs identified
2. 3x previous estimate
3. Key threshold: 1.5 degrees C (Paris Agreement)
4. Mechanism: deep water upwelling provides cooling
5. India reefs: Gulf of Mannar, Lakshadweep, Gulf of Kutch, A&N

■ UPSC TRAPS

- ✗ Bleached corals are permanently dead
- ✓ Bleached corals are stressed but not necessarily dead — if conditions improve, they can recover
- ✗ Coral reefs cover 10% of ocean surface
- ✓ Reefs cover ~0.1% of ocean surface but host ~25% of marine species

■ MAINS ANGLE

New evidence of thermally resilient reefs offers conservation hope but must not distract from urgent climate action. Discuss India's role in coral reef conservation.

■ STUDY LINK

Environment: Coral reefs; bleaching; CBD; 30x30; Paris Agreement; India's reef geography

MEDIUM

M7 — RBI FY27 CPI Forecast 5.1%; Markets Rally Post Iran Deal

GS-III: Economy
— Monetary
Policy Economy

■ NEWS TRIGGER

RBI revised its FY2026-27 CPI inflation forecast to 5.1% (from earlier 4.8%) citing monsoon risk. Markets rallied sharply after US-Iran MoU (Sensex +2.1%). Crude oil fell as Hormuz reopened. RBI's MPC uses 4% CPI target (+/- 2% band = 2-6%).

■ INTRO & ORIGIN

RBI's upward revision of inflation forecast to 5.1% for FY27 reflects the monsoon deficit risk to food prices. The market rally post-Iran deal shows the direct link between Hormuz reopening (crude oil supply) and domestic inflation expectations.

RBI's Monetary Policy Committee (MPC) — 6 members (3 RBI + 3 external) — has a mandate to maintain CPI inflation at 4% (+/- 2% band: 2-6%). Consecutive breaches of 6% for 3 quarters require RBI to write to government explaining failure. Crude oil prices directly affect India's import bill and inflation.

■ TIMELINE

2016 — Flexible Inflation Targeting (FIT) framework adopted; MPC constituted

FY27 target — CPI: 4% (+/- 2%); RBI revised forecast to 5.1%

June 15, 2026 — US-Iran MoU: Hormuz reopens; crude falls; markets rally

June 17, 2026 — Sensex +2.1%; Brent crude -4.3%

■ KEY DATA

Parameter	Value
RBI FY27 CPI forecast	5.1%
CPI target	4% (+/- 2% band: 2-6%)
MPC composition	6 members (3 RBI + 3 external)
FIT framework adopted	2016
Sensex rally post-Iran deal	+2.1%

■ STATIC THEORY

- MPC = Monetary Policy Committee: 6 members — RBI Governor (Chair), Dy Governor, 1 RBI Officer, 3 external (Govt nominated)
- CPI target: 4% +/- 2% (2-6% band); mandate under RBI Act 1934 (amended 2016)
- Repo rate = rate at which RBI lends to commercial banks (short-term)
- Imported inflation: rise in global commodity prices (crude, edible oil) raises domestic inflation

■ MUST-KNOW FACTS

1. RBI FY27 CPI forecast: 5.1%
2. CPI target: 4% (+/- 2% band: 2-6%)
3. MPC: 6 members (3 RBI + 3 external)
4. MPC constituted: 2016 (FIT framework)
5. Sensex rally: +2.1% post Iran MoU

■ UPSC TRAPS

- ✗ RBI's MPC has 7 members
- ✓ MPC has 6 members: 3 from RBI + 3 external nominated by Government
- ✗ RBI's inflation target is 5%
- ✓ CPI target = 4% with +/- 2% tolerance band (2% to 6%)

■ MAINS ANGLE

Analyse how geopolitical events (Iran deal, crude price movements) transmit into India's domestic inflation and RBI's monetary policy decisions.

■ STUDY LINK

Economy: Monetary policy; MPC; CPI; Imported inflation; Flexible Inflation Targeting

MEDIUM

M8 — Kerala: Free Bus Travel for Women + Transgender (Priyadarshini)

GS-II: Social Justice; Welfare Schemes Social Justice

■ NEWS TRIGGER

Kerala launched 'Priyadarshini' scheme: free bus travel for all women and transgender persons on KSRTC buses. Aims to increase women's workforce participation and safety in public transport.

■ INTRO & ORIGIN

Kerala's Priyadarshini scheme is a welfare measure targeting women's mobility — a key barrier to workforce participation. The scheme covers KSRTC (state-run bus service) and is funded from state budget. It follows Tamil Nadu and Karnataka which launched similar schemes in 2023.

Studies show women's access to affordable public transport directly increases labour force participation. Kerala's female LFPR is ~38% — higher than national average (~30%). The scheme also extends to transgender persons. Similar schemes: Shakti (Karnataka, 2023), Free Travel (Tamil Nadu).

■ TIMELINE

2023 — Karnataka: Shakti scheme — free bus travel for women

2023 — Tamil Nadu: similar free travel scheme

June 2026 — Kerala: Priyadarshini — free travel for women + transgender on KSRTC

■ KEY DATA

Scheme	State	Coverage
Priyadarshini	Kerala	Women + transgender on KSRTC

Scheme	State	Coverage
Shakti	Karnataka	All women on state buses (2023)
Free Travel	Tamil Nadu	Women on state buses (2023)

■ **STATIC THEORY**

- KSRTC = Kerala State Road Transport Corporation: state-owned public transport
- LFPR = Labour Force Participation Rate: % of working-age population employed or seeking work
- Transgender Persons Act 2019: prohibits discrimination; welfare measures for transgender community
- Article 15(3): State can make special provisions for women and children

■ **MUST-KNOW FACTS**

1. Scheme name: Priyadarshini
2. State: Kerala
3. Coverage: All women + transgender persons on KSRTC
4. Similar: Shakti (Karnataka 2023), Tamil Nadu free travel
5. Legal backing: Art 15(3) allows special provisions for women

■ **UPSC TRAPS**

- ✗ Priyadarshini scheme covers all public transport in Kerala
- ✓ Scheme covers KSRTC (state-run buses) — not private buses or railways
- ✗ This is India's first free bus travel scheme for women
- ✓ Karnataka (Shakti, 2023) and Tamil Nadu were earlier — Kerala is following the trend

■ **MAINS ANGLE**

Free public transport for women: Is it a sustainable welfare measure or a fiscal burden that crowds out productive investment? Examine with reference to India's experience.

■ **STUDY LINK**

Social Justice: Women welfare; LFPR; Art 15(3); Transgender Persons Act 2019

MEDIUM

M9 — PM-VBRY: 60 Lakh Beneficiaries

GS-II:
Governance —
Welfare
Schemes
Governance

■ **NEWS TRIGGER**

PM Vishwakarma Bharatiya Rojgar Yojana (PM-VBRY) has reached 60 lakh beneficiaries — 18 lakh women. Linked to Employment Linked Incentive (ELI) scheme. Targets traditional craftspersons (artisans, weavers, carpenters). Part of PM's skill + employment push.

■ **INTRO & ORIGIN**

PM-VBRY is a targeted scheme for traditional craftspersons and artisans — 18 traditional trades covered. With 60 lakh beneficiaries (18 lakh women), it represents a significant scale. The ELI (Employment Linked Incentive) provides formal employment incentives.

PM Vishwakarma scheme was launched on Vishwakarma Jayanti (September 17, 2023) — PM Modi's birthday. It provides tools, training, credit, and market linkage to 18 traditional trades. Budget: Rs 13,000 crore over 5 years. ELI scheme (Budget 2024-25) provides incentives to EPFO-registered employers for new hires.

■ **TIMELINE**

Sept 17, 2023 — PM Vishwakarma scheme launched (Rs 13,000 crore; 18 trades)

2024-25 — ELI scheme announced — employment-linked incentives via EPFO

■ KEY DATA

Parameter	Detail
Total beneficiaries	60 lakh
Women beneficiaries	18 lakh
Launch date	September 17, 2023 (Vishwakarma Jayanti)
Budget	Rs 13,000 crore (5 years)
Trades covered	18 traditional crafts
Ministry	MSME Ministry

■ STATIC THEORY

- PM Vishwakarma: 18 traditional trades; credit up to Rs 3 lakh at 5% interest; free training 5-7 days
- ELI = Employment Linked Incentive: EPFO-based; employer gets subsidy for new formal hires
- EPFO = Employees' Provident Fund Organisation: under Ministry of Labour; manages PF for formal workers
- MSMEs: 99% of enterprises in India; employ ~110 million people

■ MUST-KNOW FACTS

1. PM-VBRY beneficiaries: 60 lakh total, 18 lakh women
2. Launched: September 17, 2023 (Vishwakarma Jayanti)
3. Budget: Rs 13,000 crore (5 years)
4. Trades covered: 18 traditional crafts
5. ELI: Employment Linked Incentive (EPFO-based, Budget 2024-25)

■ UPSC TRAPS

- ✗ PM Vishwakarma targets IT/software workers
- ✓ PM Vishwakarma targets TRADITIONAL craftspersons — blacksmiths, carpenters, potters, weavers etc.
- ✗ ELI is a direct cash transfer to workers
- ✓ ELI = incentive to EMPLOYERS for hiring new EPFO-registered workers (not direct transfer to workers)

■ MAINS ANGLE

PM-VBRY and ELI represent a shift to employment-linked welfare. Critically evaluate whether incentivising informal artisans through formal EPFO channels is sufficient for inclusive growth.

■ STUDY LINK

Governance: Skill India; MSME; PM Vishwakarma; ELI; EPFO; Gig economy

■ LOW UPSC RELEVANCE

LOW

L1 — Vijay (TVK) as Tamil Nadu CM: Editorial Analysis

GS-I: Society —
Dravidian
Politics
Society/Polity

■ NEWS TRIGGER

Editorial analysis of actor-politician Vijay's Tamilaga Vettri Kazhagam (TVK) party's rise. The Hindu draws parallels with MGR (M.G. Ramachandran) who also transitioned from actor to CM. Dravidian movement context.

■ INTRO & ORIGIN

■ TIMELINE

The Vijay/TVK phenomenon represents the continuing tradition in Tamil Nadu politics where cinema intersects with Dravidian ideology. The editorial examines whether TVK's populist welfare promises differ from established Dravidian parties (DMK, AIADMK). MGR (1977-87) remains the template for actor-CM success.

Tamil Nadu politics has been defined by the Dravidian movement — founded by E.V. Ramasamy 'Periyar' (Self-Respect Movement, 1925) and C.N. Annadurai (DMK, 1949). MGR founded AIADMK (1972) and became CM (1977). Vijay's TVK is a new entrant positioning itself on welfare + Tamil pride + anti-corruption platform.

1925 — Periyar's Self-Respect Movement

1949 — DMK founded by C.N. Annadurai

1972 — MGR founds AIADMK

1977 — MGR becomes Tamil Nadu CM (first actor-CM)

2023 — Vijay launches TVK (Tamilaga Vettri Kazhagam)

■ KEY DATA

Party	Founder	Year
DMK	C.N. Annadurai	1949
AIADMK	MGR (M.G. Ramachandran)	1972
TVK	Vijay (Thalapathy)	2023

■ STATIC THEORY

- Dravidian movement: anti-Brahmin, social justice, Tamil identity based ideology
- DMK = Dravida Munnetra Kazhagam; AIADMK = All India Anna Dravida Munnetra Kazhagam
- Periyar = E.V. Ramasamy: rationalist social reformer; Self-Respect Movement 1925

■ MUST-KNOW FACTS

1. Vijay's party: TVK (Tamilaga Vettri Kazhagam) — founded 2023
2. Dravidian movement: Periyar (Self-Respect) to Annadurai (DMK) to MGR (AIADMK)
3. MGR: first actor-CM of Tamil Nadu (1977-87)
4. DMK founded: 1949 by C.N. Annadurai

■ UPSC TRAPS

- ✗ AIADMK was founded by Jayalalithaa
- ✓ AIADMK was founded by MGR (1972); Jayalalithaa was his successor

■ MAINS ANGLE

Examine how Tamil Nadu's Dravidian political tradition shapes state welfare policy and social justice outcomes — and what TVK's rise signals for this tradition.

■ STUDY LINK

Society: Dravidian movement; Tamil Nadu politics; Social reform movements in India

LOW

L2 — Telangana Breakfast Scheme: 29 Lakh Students

GS-II: Social Justice — Welfare Social Justice

■ NEWS TRIGGER

Telangana's school breakfast scheme covering 29 lakh government school students; budget Rs 740 crore. Nutritious breakfast before classes to improve attendance and learning outcomes. Complements PM-POSHAN (Mid-Day Meal) scheme which covers lunch.

■ INTRO & ORIGIN Telangana's breakfast scheme complements the national Mid-Day Meal (PM-POSHAN) scheme which covers lunch. Providing breakfast addresses morning hunger — a key barrier to school attendance in poor households. At Rs 740 crore for 29 lakh students, it is one of India's largest school nutrition programmes. <i>PM-POSHAN (formerly Mid-Day Meal) covers lunch for Classes 1-8 in government schools. Telangana's scheme fills the breakfast gap. Studies show morning nutrition directly improves attention and learning. SDG Goal 2 (Zero Hunger) and Goal 4 (Quality Education) are directly linked.</i>	■ TIMELINE 1995 — Mid-Day Meal scheme nationally launched 2021 — Renamed PM-POSHAN 2026 — Telangana launches breakfast scheme (29 lakh students, Rs 740 cr)
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■ KEY DATA		
Scheme	Meal	Coverage
PM-POSHAN	Lunch	Classes 1-8 nationally (government schools)
Telangana Breakfast	Breakfast	All govt school students, Telangana

■ STATIC THEORY - PM-POSHAN (formerly Mid-Day Meal): covers lunch for Classes 1-8 in government schools - National Food Security Act 2013: subsidised food grains for BPL families - SDG Goal 2: Zero Hunger; Goal 4: Quality Education

■ MUST-KNOW FACTS 29 lakh government school students covered - Budget: Rs 740 crore - State: Telangana - Complements PM-POSHAN (Mid-Day Meal for lunch)	■ UPSC TRAPS ✗ PM-POSHAN covers both breakfast and lunch ✓ PM-POSHAN covers LUNCH only; Telangana's scheme separately covers breakfast
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■ MAINS ANGLE <i>School nutrition programmes reduce dropout rates and improve cognitive outcomes. Should breakfast provision be nationalised under PM-POSHAN?</i>	■ STUDY LINK Social Justice: PM-POSHAN; NFSA 2013; SDG 2 and 4; School education
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LOW L3 — Sarpreet Singh: First Indian-Origin Player to Start FIFA World Cup GS-I: Society — Sports Sports		
■ NEWS TRIGGER Sarpreet Singh (New Zealand), of Indian-Punjabi origin, became the first player of Indian origin to START (not just play) a FIFA World Cup match. New Zealand at 2026 FIFA World Cup (USA/Canada/Mexico). 2026 WC is first 48-team format.		
■ INTRO & ORIGIN	■ TIMELINE	

Sarpreet Singh's milestone is historically significant for the Indian diaspora in football. He was born in New Zealand to Punjabi immigrant parents. His selection to start a World Cup match marks a first for the Indian-origin sporting community internationally.

The 2026 FIFA World Cup is hosted jointly by USA, Canada, and Mexico — the first three-country hosting and first 48-team format (expanded from 32). Sarpreet Singh represents the increasing global spread of the Indian diaspora across professional sports.

2026 — FIFA World Cup (USA/Canada/Mexico) — 48 teams; Sarpreet Singh starts for New Zealand

■ KEY DATA

Fact	Detail
Player	Sarpreet Singh (New Zealand)
Origin	Indian-Punjabi descent
Milestone	First Indian-origin starter at FIFA World Cup
Tournament	2026 FIFA WC (USA/Canada/Mexico)
Format	48 teams (first time, expanded from 32)

■ STATIC THEORY

- 2026 FIFA World Cup: first 48-team format; hosted by USA, Canada, Mexico (3 countries for first time)
- Indian diaspora: ~35 million Indians abroad; largest diaspora globally

■ MUST-KNOW FACTS

1. Sarpreet Singh: New Zealand player; Indian-Punjabi origin
2. First Indian-origin player to START (not just play) a FIFA World Cup match
3. 2026 FIFA World Cup: USA, Canada, Mexico — 48 teams

■ UPSC TRAPS

- ✗ Sarpreet Singh plays for India
- ✓ Singh plays for New Zealand — he is of Indian origin but represents NZ nationally

■ MAINS ANGLE

Indian diaspora achievements in global sports — what does it reveal about integration, identity, and India's own sports development gap?

■ STUDY LINK

Society: Indian diaspora; Sports governance in India; Soft power

LOW

L4 — Ukrainian Drone Hits Gazprom Oil Refinery Near Moscow

GS-II:
International
Relations
International
Relations

■ NEWS TRIGGER

Ukrainian long-range drone struck Gazprom-linked oil refinery facility near Moscow. First significant energy infrastructure attack reaching Moscow suburbs. Signals Ukrainian drone range extension and shift to strategic infrastructure targeting.

■ INTRO & ORIGIN

Ukraine's long-range drone campaign has reached Moscow's energy infrastructure — a significant escalation. India buys significant volumes of Russian oil at discounted prices — any major disruption to Russian energy infrastructure affects India's energy import calculations.

■ TIMELINE

Feb 2022 — Russia invades Ukraine

Russia invaded Ukraine on February 24, 2022. Since then, India has significantly increased Russian oil imports (discounts of \$20-30 per barrel). Gazprom = Russia's state-owned natural gas monopoly. Ukraine's drone attacks on Russian oil/energy infrastructure started 2024 and have escalated through 2026.

2022-24 — India increases Russian oil imports (discounts)

June 2026 — Ukraine drone hits Gazprom refinery near Moscow

■ KEY DATA

Actor	Key Interest
Ukraine	Strategic pressure on Russian economy
Russia	Protect energy infrastructure; fund war
India	Discounted oil; diplomatic neutrality
EU/US	Pressure Russia; support Ukraine

■ STATIC THEORY

- Gazprom: Russian state-owned gas company; world's largest natural gas producer
- India's energy security: diversified suppliers; ~35-40% of crude now from Russia
- SWIFT sanctions: Western financial sanctions on Russia; India avoids these

■ MUST-KNOW FACTS

1. Target: Gazprom-linked oil refinery near Moscow
2. Gazprom = Russian state natural GAS company (primary); has oil subsidiaries
3. India's Russian oil share: ~35-40% of crude imports
4. Russia-Ukraine war started: February 24, 2022

■ UPSC TRAPS

- ✗ Gazprom is primarily an oil company
- ✓ Gazprom = state natural GAS company (largest globally); it has oil subsidiaries but gas is primary

■ MAINS ANGLE

How does the Ukraine-Russia war's escalation into energy infrastructure attacks affect India's energy security and diplomatic balancing act?

■ STUDY LINK

IR: Russia-Ukraine war; Energy security; India-Russia relations; Gazprom

LOW

L5 — Ram Mandir Trust Donation Controversy

GS-II:
Governance —
Civil Society
Governance

■ NEWS TRIGGER

Congress demands SIT probe into alleged irregularities in Ram Mandir Trust (Shri Ram Janmabhoomi Teerth Kshetra Trust) donations and land purchases. Opposition alleges opaque financial transactions in publicly-collected trust funds.

■ INTRO & ORIGIN

The Ram Mandir Trust controversy highlights governance gaps in large religious trusts managing public donations. The trust collected over Rs 3,000 crore in public donations for Ram Mandir construction (inaugurated January 2024). Opposition allegations involve irregular land purchases near Ayodhya.

■ TIMELINE

Nov 2019 — SC Ayodhya verdict — land to Ram Janmabhoomi side

SC Ayodhya verdict: November 9, 2019 — 5-judge bench gave land to Ram Janmabhoomi side. Trust constituted February 2020. Ram Mandir inaugurated January 22, 2024 (PM Modi). Trust collected Rs 3,000+ crore in public campaign. Congress alleges trust members made personal gains through land purchases near Ayodhya using trust connections.

Feb 2020 — Ram Mandir Trust constituted

Jan 22, 2024 — Ram Mandir inaugurated (PM Modi)

June 2026 — Congress demands SIT probe into Trust donations

■ KEY DATA

Fact	Detail
Trust name	Shri Ram Janmabhoomi Teerth Kshetra Trust
Constituted	February 2020
Inauguration	January 22, 2024
Donations collected	Rs 3,000+ crore (public campaign)
SC verdict	November 9, 2019

■ STATIC THEORY

- Religious trusts: regulated under Public Trust Act (state-wise) or Societies Act
- SIT = Special Investigation Team: constituted by courts or government for specific investigations
- FCRA: applies to foreign donations to religious/civil society organisations
- Ayodhya verdict (2019): SC five-judge bench; land to Hindu side; Muslims to get alternative 5 acres

■ MUST-KNOW FACTS

1. Trust: Shri Ram Janmabhoomi Teerth Kshetra Trust
2. Constituted: February 2020
3. Ram Mandir inaugurated: January 22, 2024
4. Donations: Rs 3,000+ crore collected publicly
5. SC Ayodhya verdict: November 9, 2019

■ UPSC TRAPS

- ✗ Ram Mandir Trust is a government body
- ✓ Trust is a private religious trust — constituted by government resolution but not a government entity
- ✗ SC Ayodhya verdict was in 2020
- ✓ SC Ayodhya verdict was on November 9, 2019

■ MAINS ANGLE

What accountability and transparency framework should govern large religious trusts that collect public donations at scale in India?

■ STUDY LINK

Governance: Trust law; Public donations; SC Ayodhya verdict 2019; Religious institutions accountability